

Learning a Language

Unlike other species, humans have a brain with regions dedicated to language. Babies are born ready to learn language, acquiring it through an interplay between these specialized areas of the brain and their own unique experiences. To learn language, we also have to interact with other people.

Learning to talk

Our innate preference for looking at faces helps newborns focus attention on people talking to them. Later, making eye contact and following gaze allows them to connect the words they hear with what is being talked about. As they learn new words, infants make “overextension” errors by using a single word to label multiple things, for example, by using the word “fly” to refer to anything small and dark.

Timeline of speech

The exact timescale for mastering language varies from child to child, but all children progress through the main stages in a similar order—from cooing and babbling to first words and, ultimately, full sentences.

